

Composed, Not Translated

The book refuses to translate its Arabic. The reason is commercial rather than sentimental, and it decides how a founder in this region should write everything a customer reads.

“Speaks the way they speak — Egyptian colloquial, composed not translated. If it reads as a translation, it was written wrong.”

StartPad Brand Presentation, GrowthLabs Group, 2026 · Chapter 05 · The voice

A translation is detectable, and being detected is the cost.

The rule is not about respect and it is not about reach. It is about a specific signal: text that has been translated reads as translated, and a reader who notices concludes that they were not the audience the thing was made for. That conclusion is expensive and it is arrived at in about two seconds.

The book goes further than most brands would dare, setting Arabic at hero scale with English small and precisely aligned beneath it — explicitly a translation register, not two equal languages competing. It also rules that everyday assets carry one language only. Both decisions are worth a founder's attention, because both cost something and were taken anyway.

Structure survives translation. That is the problem.

Words translate; sentence shape does not. A paragraph composed in English and rendered into Arabic keeps English clause order, English hedging and English idiom underneath the Arabic vocabulary. Native readers do not need to identify what is wrong to register that something is.

COMPOSED

Written first in the language the reader uses

Idiom that belongs to the reader's city, not to a dictionary

Length set by what the language needs to say it

Checked by somebody who would use it in conversation

TRANSLATED

Written in English, then converted

Idiom that is technically correct and used by nobody

Length inherited from the English original

Checked for accuracy rather than for naturalness

The right column is usually accurate. Accuracy is not what is being judged — belonging is, and a reader makes that judgement before they finish the first line.

The cheapest test available

Read your Arabic copy out loud to somebody who speaks it daily and watch their face, not their notes. Hesitation is the finding. If they say "it's correct, but nobody says it like that", it was translated, and that sentence is worth more than any review round.

Bilingual everything is a decision nobody made.

The default in this region is to put both languages on everything, which feels safe and is rarely chosen deliberately. The book takes the opposite position for everyday assets: one language each. The reason is that a bilingual asset is half wasted on every reader, and the half they are not reading is competing for the space that would have made the half they are reading land.

ASSET	THE BOOK'S RULE	THE FOUNDER EQUIVALENT
Everyday asset — a post, an ad, a page	One language per asset.	Two versions, each composed. Not one with both languages stacked.
Hero — a campaign line, a headline	Arabic large, English small beneath, precisely aligned.	Lead in the language of the market you are selling to.
Institutional — a contract, a data room	Whatever the reader requires, plainly.	English for most regional investors; Arabic where the counterparty works in it.

The practical objection is cost: two composed versions is more work than one translated pair. It is, and the work is the point. A founder who cannot afford two composed versions should pick one language and do it properly rather than produce two halves.

Your customers do not read your deck. They read your form.

Founders pour attention into investor-facing English and leave the customer-facing Arabic to whoever had time. It is exactly backwards: the deck is read once by somebody who is paid to read carefully, and the form, the error message and the confirmation are read by every customer at the moment they decide whether to trust you.

MOST CONSEQUENTIAL

The moment money is asked for

A checkout line or a price. Composed, or the hesitation costs the sale.

Error and failure messages

Read at the worst moment. A translated apology reads as indifference.

The form fields and their labels

The most-read text you own, and usually the least edited.

Onboarding and confirmations

Sets whether the thing feels made for them.

Marketing copy

Where all the attention goes, and the least consequential of the five.

LEAST

Ranked by what a badly composed line actually costs. The order is close to the inverse of where most founders spend their editing time.

Worksheet · The composition audit

ONE HOUR

Go through the product and the funnel, not the marketing site.

The five pieces of text a customer is most likely to read

Count, do not guess. Your analytics or your own funnel will tell you.

Which of those five were composed, and which were translated

The one that sits closest to the moment money is asked for

Who will compose it — name a person, not a service

Somebody who speaks it daily and is allowed to change the meaning, not just the words.

What I will stop translating entirely

One language done properly beats two done halfway, and costs less.

On the founder writing it themselves

If you speak the language your customers use, write the customer-facing text yourself, badly, and have somebody tidy it. That produces better copy than a professional translation of your English, because the structure starts in the right place.

SAY

Written the way a customer would say it.

One language, done properly.

Somebody who uses it daily read it aloud.

We do not translate the checkout.

NEVER SAY

Fully localised for the MENA market.

Available in English and Arabic.

Reviewed by a native speaker.

Our platform supports multiple languages.

The book pairs this rule with a typographic one: Arabic is set in Zain, chosen on its own terms rather than bent to mimic the Latin, because forcing an Arabic face to match a geometric construction always reads as a compromise. The same instinct applies to the words.



StartPad tells you the truth about whether you are ready, gets you ready, and gives you the proof.

What it is

A founder-readiness platform for Egypt and the wider MENA region. It takes a young person who has an idea and no company, moves them through fifteen structured missions, and turns them into someone the ecosystem will take seriously — then issues verifiable proof of that.

It is not a course platform, not an education brand and not a youth club. Nothing here is graded. Every mission ends in an artefact you own.

Three moves, always in this order

TRUTH Where you actually stand

Measured against what programmes actually ask for, stated plainly, before any encouragement.

READINESS Fifteen structured missions

They close the specific gaps the assessment found, in the order that matters. A route, not a curriculum.

PROOF A verifiable credential

The ecosystem can check it without asking you. You apply with a file, not a hope.

On your idea

StartPad earns when a founder gets into somewhere — an accelerator, a programme, a room. Taking a founder's idea would end that. Work submitted to a mission is sealed and timestamped to the person who submitted it, and the seal is the product.

Nothing in this document asks you to give anything up to use it. It is yours to fill in, print, and hand to whoever needs to see it.

startpad.me

Start with the readiness assessment. It is free and it takes about twenty minutes.